STRAIT OF HORMUZ

Maritime Disruption Report

Analysis of the February 2026 strait closure: vessel transit collapse, crude oil price impact, trade volume disruption, and early signals of diplomatic reopening.

Author	Vincent Ngo
Date	April 2026
Data Sources	IMF PortWatch (AIS), FRED (EIA), WTO Data Lab
Coverage	January 2019 – April 2026

This report uses publicly available AIS satellite data from the IMF PortWatch platform and crude oil price data from the Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED) system. All data is subject to the limitations of AIS tracking, including transponder disabling and GPS interference in conflict zones.

CONTENTS

Executive Summary 3
The Collapse — 48-Hour Cliff 4
Oil Price Impact — WTI-Brent Spread Blowout 6
Vessel Mix Shift — Who's Still Transiting? 7
The March 30 Ceasefire Signal 8
Scale Comparison — COVID vs Hormuz 9
Trade Volume Loss 10

SECTION 01

Executive Summary

-91.8%	$23.83	13x	3.35M
Daily vessel transits vs pre-closure	Peak WTI-Brent spread (from $3.96)	Worse than COVID on this strait	Metric tons of trade lost per day

On 28 February 2026, Iran announced the closure of the Strait of Hormuz to commercial shipping. Within 48 hours, daily vessel transits collapsed from approximately 95 ships per day to fewer than 5 — a 91.8% decline that represents the most severe disruption to global maritime trade since records began.

The strait, which normally handles roughly 20% of global oil supply, saw tanker traffic fall by 94% and container shipping effectively cease entirely. Brent crude surged 80% from $71 to $128 per barrel, while the WTI-Brent spread — the key measure of international versus US supply vulnerability — exploded from a pre-closure average of $3.96 to a peak of $23.83, a six-fold widening.

This disruption dwarfs the COVID-19 pandemic's impact on the same strait by a factor of 13. An estimated 3.35 million metric tons of trade volume per day has been removed from global supply chains, equivalent to approximately 1.2 billion metric tons annualised. Early signs of a tentative reopening appeared on March 30, when 17 vessels — including 12 tankers — transited the strait amid US-Iran ceasefire negotiations.

SECTION 02

The Collapse — 48-Hour Cliff

The Strait of Hormuz operated at normal capacity through late February 2026, with the 7-day moving average holding steady above 90 vessels per day. The transition from fully operational to effectively shut was not gradual — it was binary. On February 27, 95 ships transited. On March 1, the count fell to 17, and by March 2, only 4 vessels made the passage. By the second week of March, daily transits stabilised at 3–5 ships.

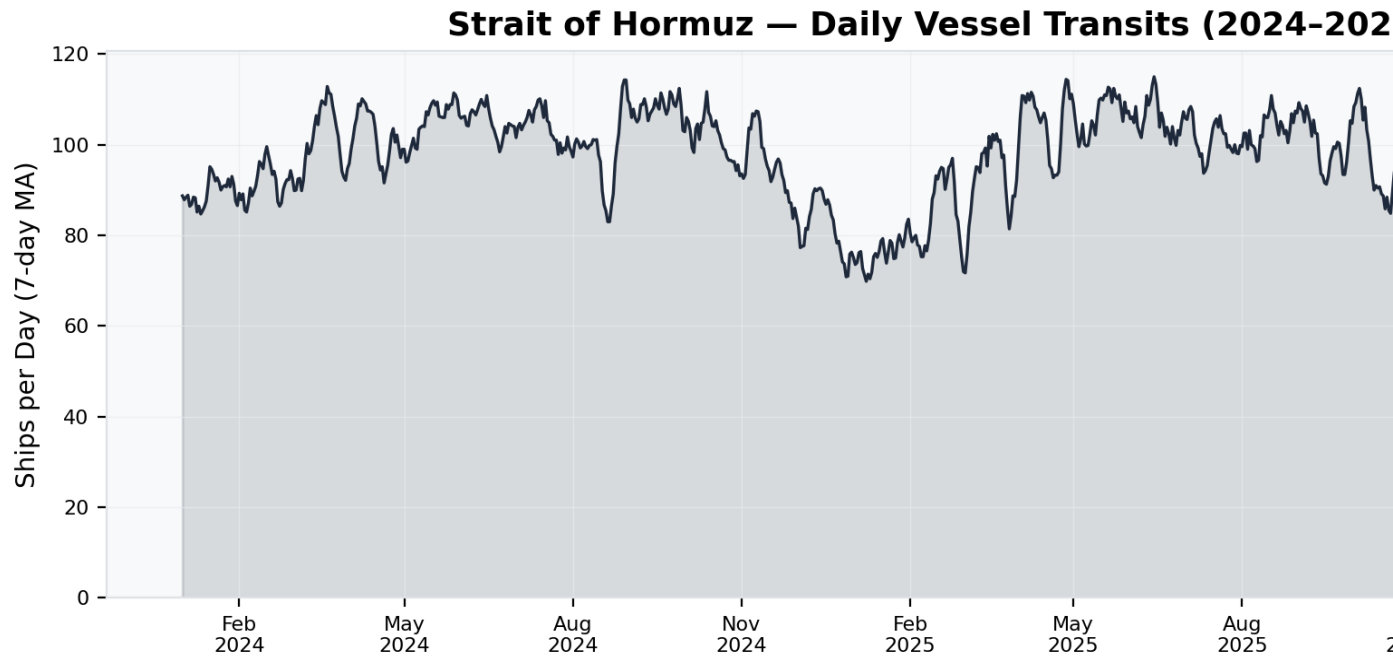


Figure 1: 7-day moving average of daily vessel transits, 2024–2026. Vertical dashed line marks the closure on 28 February 2026.

The breakdown by vessel type reveals a near-uniform shutdown across all categories. Tankers, which historically comprised the majority of traffic at approximately 55 vessels per day, dropped to an average of 3.2 per day post-closure — a 94% decline. Container shipping saw the most complete withdrawal: from roughly 17 ships per day to fewer than 1, reflecting the major liner companies' immediate suspension of Gulf services.

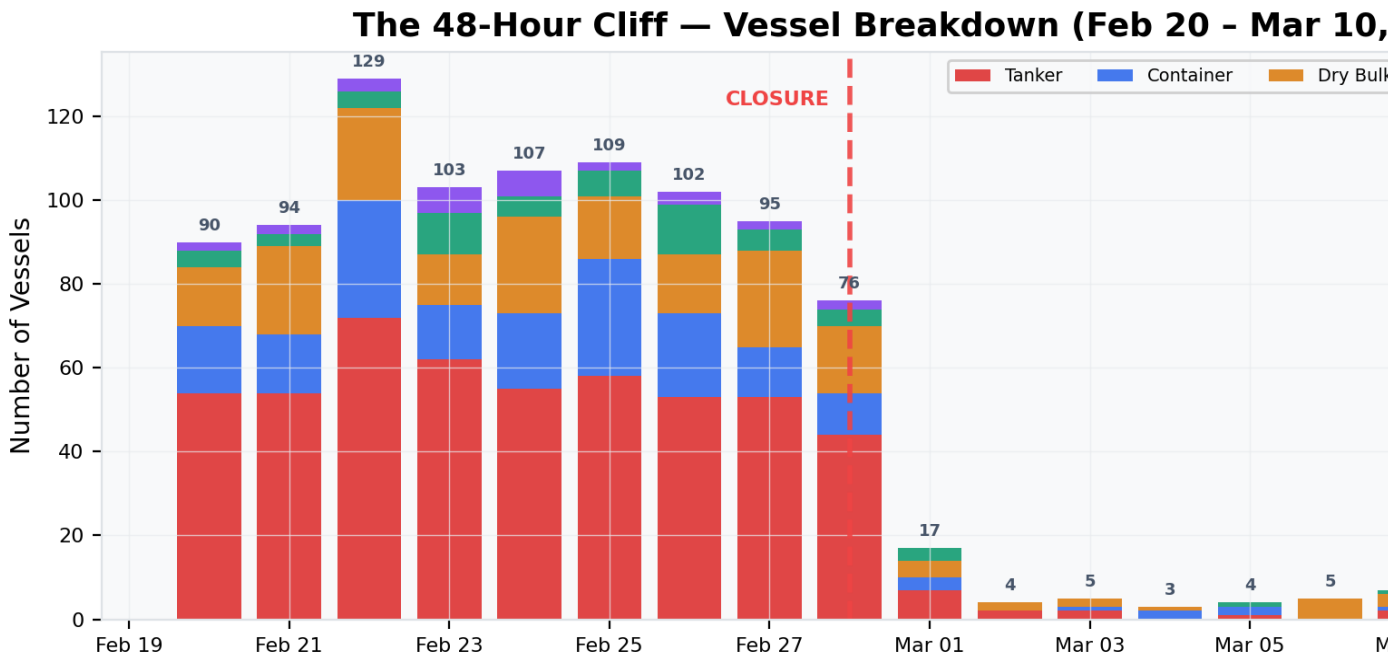


Figure 2: Daily vessel transits by type during the closure transition (Feb 20 – Mar 10, 2026).

	Feb 27 (Last Normal)	Mar 1	Mar 5 (Stabilised)	Change
Total Vessels	95	17	4	**-95.8%**
Tankers	53	7	1	**-98.1%**
Container	12	3	2	**-83.3%**
Dry Bulk	23	4	0	**-100%**

Table 1: Vessel transit counts during the closure transition.

SECTION 03

Oil Price Impact — WTI-Brent Spread Blowout

Crude oil prices responded sharply to the closure, with both benchmarks surging to multi-year highs. WTI rose from $66.96 on February 27 to $113.23 by April 2 — a 69% increase. Brent, the international benchmark, moved even more aggressively, climbing from $71.32 to $127.61, an 80% surge.

However, the headline price moves tell only part of the story. The more revealing metric is the WTI-Brent spread, which captures the differential between US domestic crude (WTI) and internationally priced crude (Brent). Pre-closure, this spread averaged $3.96, reflecting the US economy's relative energy self-sufficiency. Post-closure, the spread averaged $12.11 and peaked at $23.83 on March 31 — a six-fold widening.

This blowout reveals a critical structural insight: the Hormuz closure disproportionately affects international supply chains. Europe and Asia, which are heavily dependent on Gulf crude, face acute shortages, while the US — as a major domestic producer and net exporter — is relatively insulated. For commodity trading desks, the spread widening created significant arbitrage and hedging opportunities across Brent/WTI futures and options.

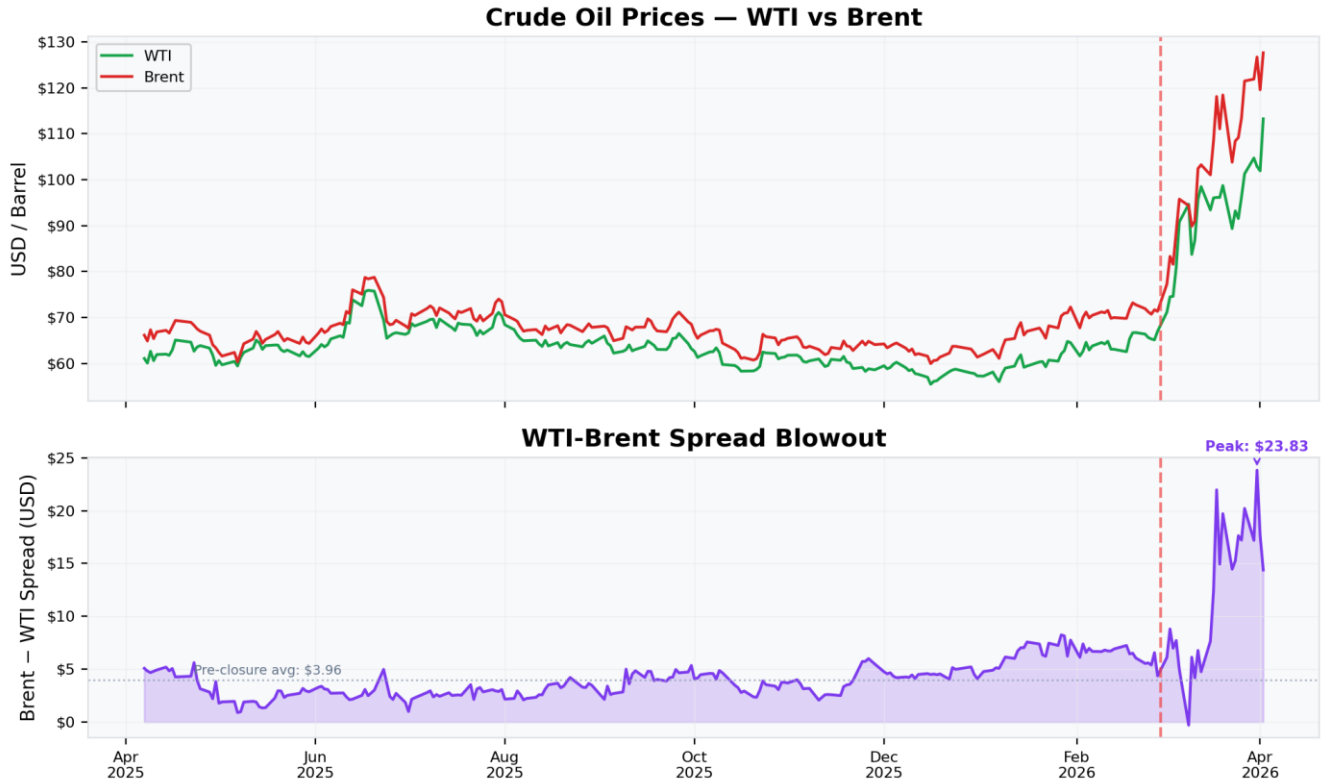


Figure 3: WTI and Brent crude prices (top) and WTI-Brent spread (bottom), Apr 2025 – Apr 2026.

	Feb 27 (Pre)	Mar 17 (Wk 3)	Mar 31 (Wk 5)	Apr 2 (Latest)	Change
WTI	$66.96	$96.01	$102.86	$113.23	**+69.1%**
Brent	$71.32	$108.39	$126.69	$127.61	**+78.9%**
Spread	$4.36	$12.38	$23.83	$14.38	**+230%**

Table 2: Crude oil price evolution during the Hormuz closure.

SECTION 04

Vessel Mix Shift — Who's Still Transiting?

The closure did not affect all vessel categories equally. Analysing the composition of the 165 ships that transited the strait between March 5 and April 5 reveals a significant shift in the traffic mix compared to normal operations.

Pre-closure, tankers dominated at 56.5% of all traffic, reflecting the strait's role as the world's primary oil transit route. Container ships represented 18.8%, and dry bulk carriers 15.8%. Post-closure, the mix shifted dramatically: tankers and dry bulk now share equal weight at 38.8% each, while container shipping collapsed to 11.5%.

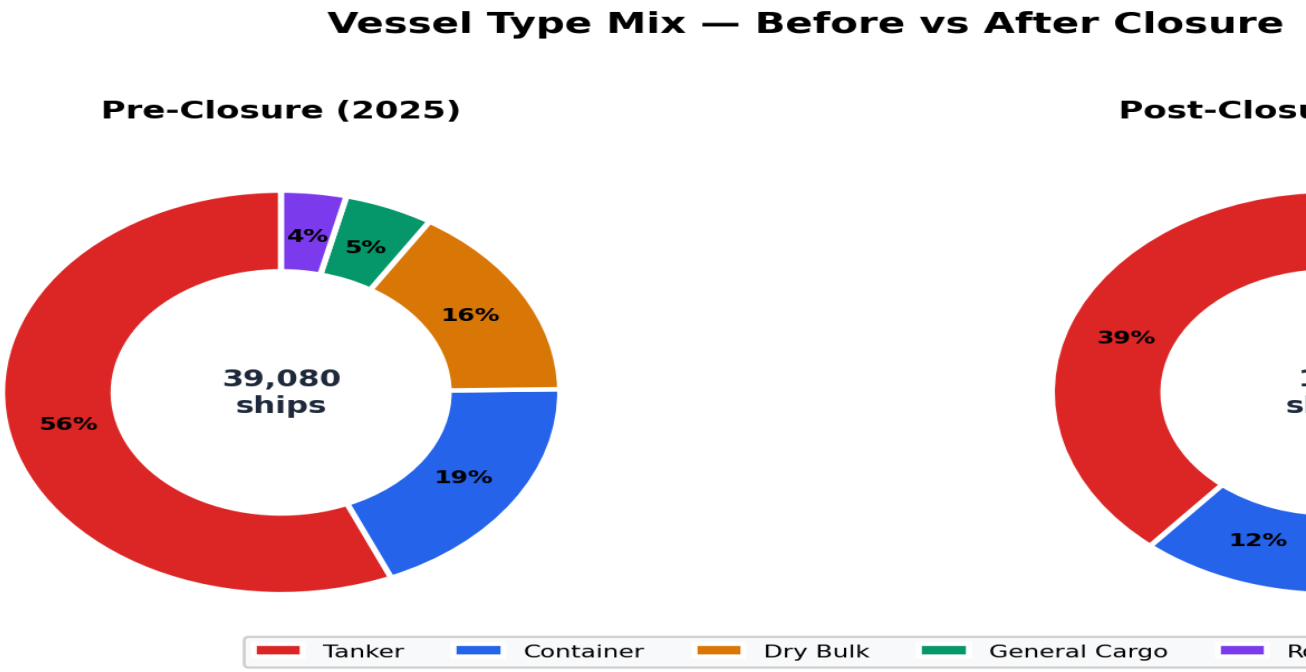


Figure 4: Vessel type composition before and after the Hormuz closure.

The near-total withdrawal of container lines reflects the major carriers' (Maersk, MSC, CMA CGM, Hapag-Lloyd) immediate suspension of Gulf services — these companies have strict risk protocols that preclude transit through active conflict zones. Their fleets have been rerouted via the Cape of Good Hope, adding 10–14 days to Asia-Europe voyages.

The relative resilience of dry bulk traffic suggests that smaller, independently operated bulk carriers — often flagged to less risk-averse registries — continue to transit, likely carrying essential commodities such as grain and fertiliser inputs. The tankers still transiting may include vessels operating under specific flag-state arrangements or carrying cargo for nations with bilateral security guarantees.

Vessel Type	Pre-Closure Share	Post-Closure Share	Change
Tanker	56.5%	38.8%	-17.7pp
Container	18.8%	11.5%	-7.3pp
Dry Bulk	15.8%	38.8%	+23.0pp
General Cargo	5.2%	10.3%	+5.1pp
Ro-Ro	3.8%	0.6%	-3.2pp

Table 3: Vessel mix shift, pre-closure (2025 avg) vs post-closure (Mar 5 – Apr 5, 2026).

SECTION 05

The March 30 Ceasefire Signal

For three weeks following the closure, daily transit counts remained remarkably stable at 3–5 vessels per day, with the 7-day moving average hovering between 2.6 and 3.4. Then, on March 30, a sharp anomaly emerged: 17 vessels transited the strait in a single day — a five-fold spike from the prior week's average.

The composition of that day's traffic is particularly telling. Of the 17 ships, 12 were tankers — oil carriers deliberately testing the viability of resuming crude shipments. This surge coincided precisely with reports that US and Iranian delegations had agreed to meet for ceasefire talks, with US President Trump publicly expressing optimism about a potential deal.

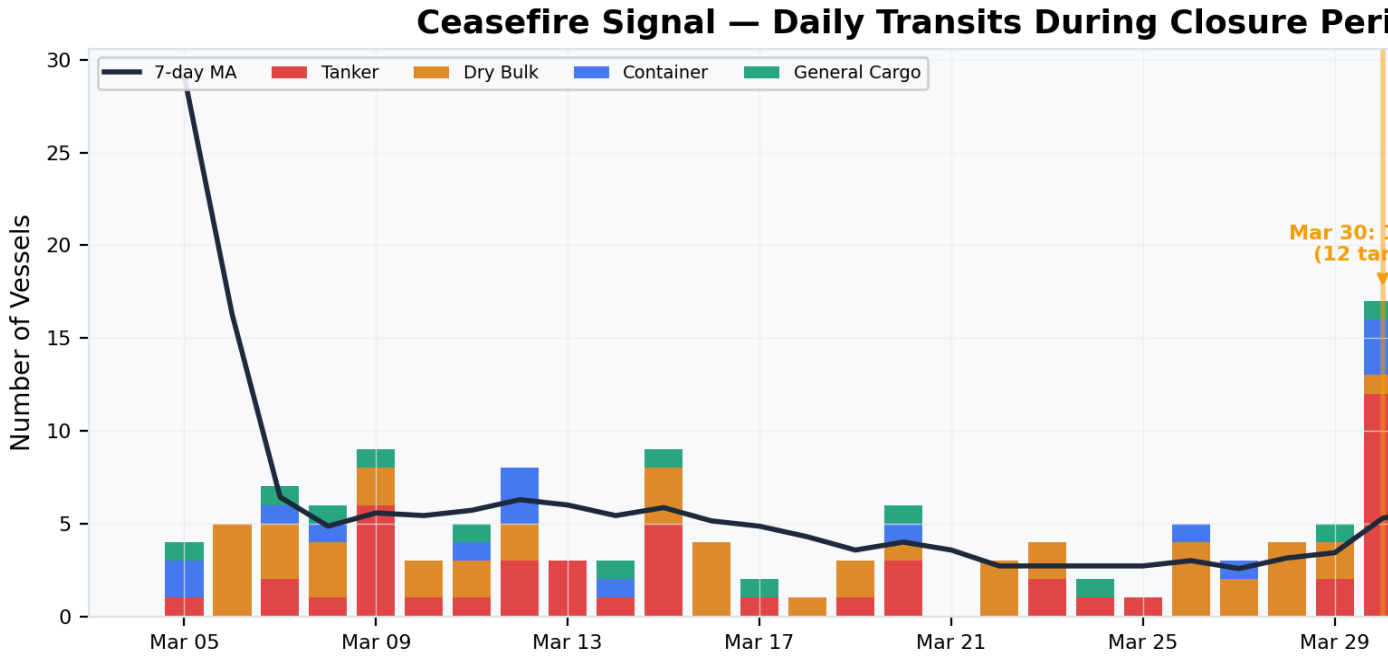


Figure 5: Daily vessel transits during the closure period with vessel type breakdown and 7-day MA.

The market interpreted this signal cautiously. While the spike suggests that some shipowners and charterers were positioning to resume Gulf trade in anticipation of a diplomatic resolution, the 7-day moving average only rose from 3.4 to 8.4 by April 5 — still more than 90% below pre-closure levels. The tentative nature of the recovery is consistent with reports that Iran was considering a permission-based transit regime, requiring military approval for each vessel passage.

For crude oil markets, the ceasefire talks initially triggered a sharp reversal — Brent dropped more than 10% in a single session on April 3 — before recovering as doubts about the ceasefire's durability resurfaced. This price action underscores the binary risk profile that Hormuz represents: even a marginal reopening signal can move billions of dollars in energy market value within hours.

SECTION 06

Scale Comparison — COVID vs Hormuz

To contextualise the severity of the current disruption, it is useful to compare it against the most significant global trade shock in recent memory: the COVID-19 pandemic. During the worst of the pandemic in early 2020 — when global demand collapsed, refineries cut throughput, and economies entered lockdown — traffic through the Strait of Hormuz dipped to approximately 65 vessels per day.

The current closure has reduced average daily transits to 5.2 vessels — making the Hormuz disruption approximately 13 times more severe than COVID's impact on the same waterway. Critically, the nature of the two shocks differs fundamentally: COVID was a demand-side shock (fewer buyers), while the Hormuz closure is a supply-side shock (physical blockage of a transit route). Supply-side disruptions tend to have more immediate and severe price impacts because production cannot be easily redirected.

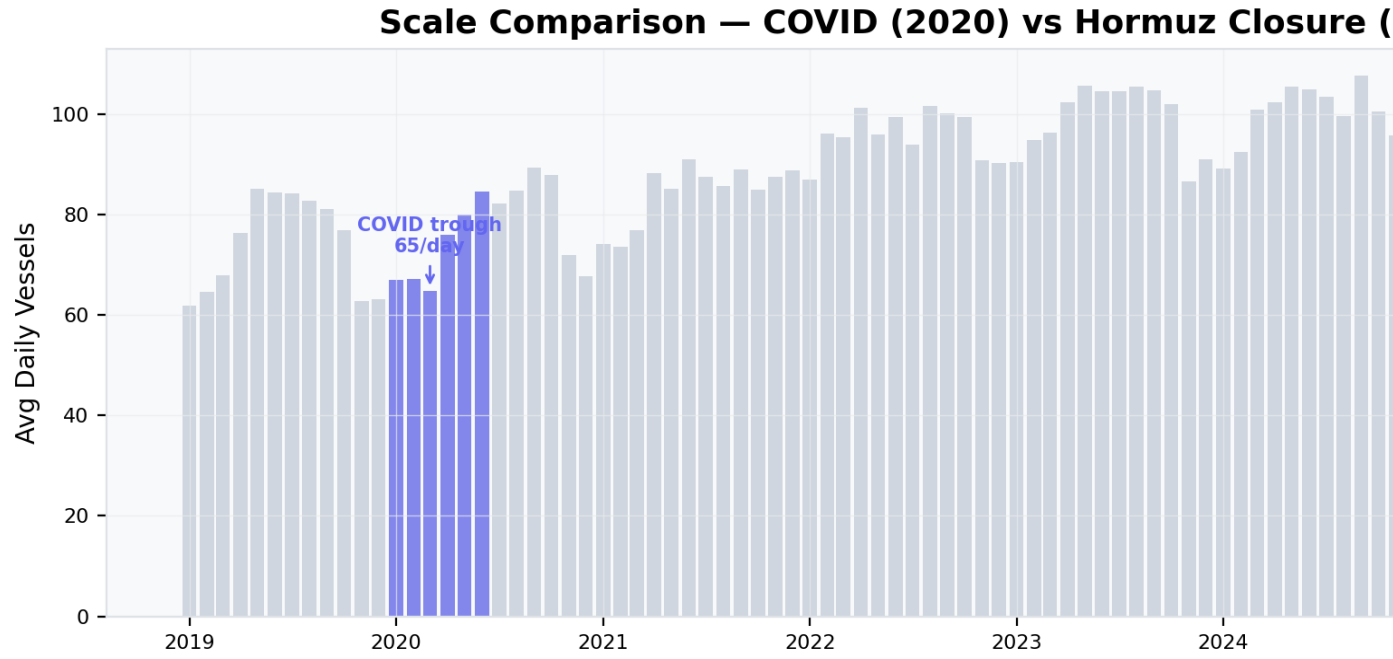


Figure 6: Monthly avg daily vessel transits, 2019–2026. COVID period (blue) vs Hormuz closure (red).

	COVID-19 (Mar 2020)	Hormuz Closure (Mar 2026)
Daily vessel avg	~65/day	~5/day
Decline from normal	-27%	-94%
Shock type	Demand-side	Supply-side
Duration	~3 months trough	Ongoing (5+ weeks)
Oil price impact	WTI briefly negative	Brent +80%
Recovery pattern	Gradual V-shape	Binary / event-driven

Table 4: COVID-19 vs Hormuz closure impact comparison.

SECTION 07

Trade Volume Loss

Beyond vessel counts, the trade volume data — measured in metric tons of cargo transiting the strait — quantifies the economic magnitude of the disruption. In 2025, the Strait of Hormuz handled an average of 3.55 million metric tons of cargo per day. Post-closure, this figure collapsed to approximately 205,000 metric tons per day — a 94.2% decline.

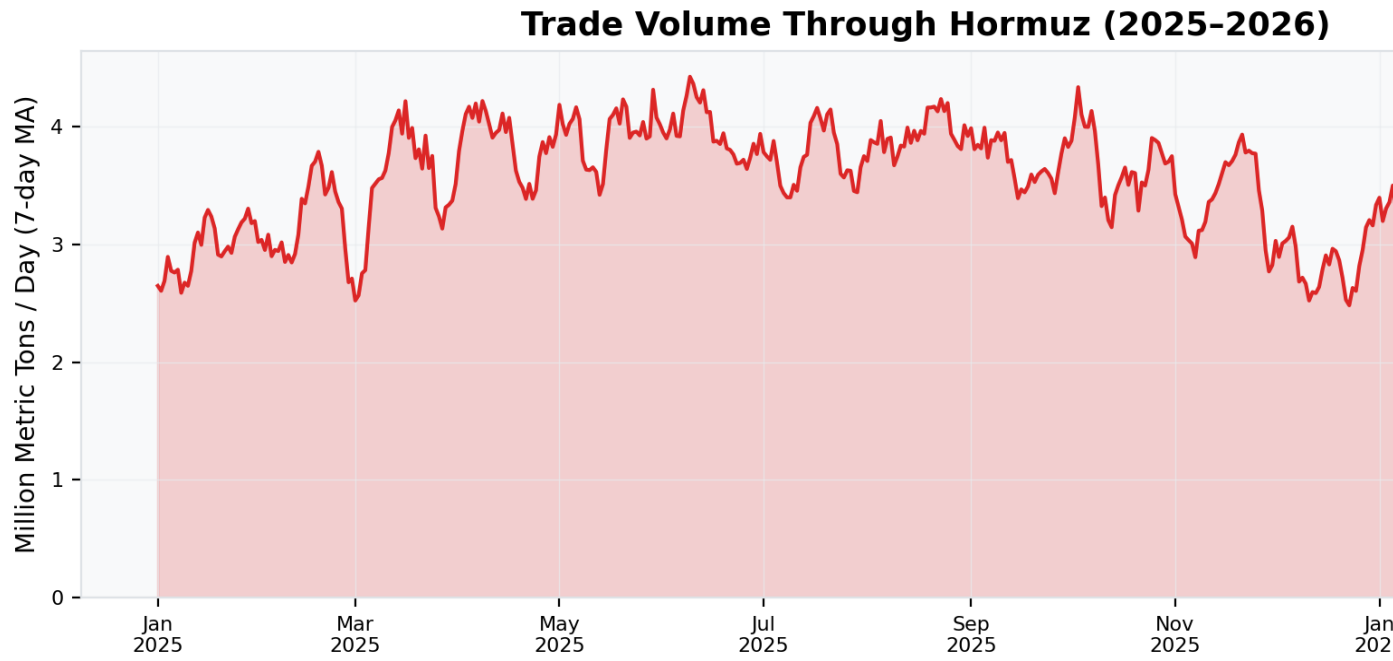


Figure 7: Daily trade volume through Hormuz (7-day MA) in million metric tons, 2025–2026.

The tanker segment, which carries crude oil and petroleum products, saw the sharpest decline: from 2.50 million metric tons per day to 127,000 — a 94.9% collapse. This translates to a daily crude oil supply removal of approximately 2.37 million metric tons, or roughly 17–18 million barrels per day using standard conversion factors.

	Pre-Closure (2025)	Post-Closure	Daily Loss
Total Volume	3.55M MT/day	205K MT/day	**3.35M MT/day**
Tanker Volume	2.50M MT/day	127K MT/day	**2.37M MT/day**
Annualised Loss			**~1.22 Billion MT/yr**

Table 5: Trade volume impact summary.

To put this in global context, the World Trade Organization estimated that the Strait of Hormuz normally handles approximately 20% of global oil supply and a significant share of global LNG exports. The bypass pipelines that exist — the East-West Pipeline (Saudi Arabia to Yanbu) and the ADCOP pipeline (Abu Dhabi to Fujairah) — have a combined nameplate capacity of roughly 7 million barrels per day, covering only about 35% of the strait's normal throughput. With reports of attacks on Saudi pipeline infrastructure reducing capacity further, the effective bypass coverage is likely lower still.

DATA SOURCES & METHODOLOGY

Vessel transit data: IMF PortWatch platform (portwatch.imf.org), jointly developed by the IMF and the Environmental Change Institute at the University of Oxford. Data derived from satellite-captured AIS signals from approximately 90,000 vessels worldwide. Vessel counts represent lower bounds due to transponder disabling and signal interference in conflict zones.

Crude oil prices: Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED), Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis. WTI series: DCOILWTICO (daily, Cushing, Oklahoma). Brent series: DCOILBRENTEU (daily, Europe). Original source: U.S. Energy Information Administration.

Supplementary context: WTO Data Lab Strait of Hormuz Trade Tracker (datalab.wto.org); HormuzTracker.com; carrier status reports from Maersk, MSC, Hapag-Lloyd, and ONE.